environment for expansion of both China's and India's ties with Iran. This led China, soon followed by India, to seek closer partnership with Iran.

Throughout the long and tangled conflict between Washington and Tehran, the United States often found it desirable to secure China's political support. Less frequently, Washington found it needed Indian support on Iran-related issues, but starting with the formation of the new Indo–US strategic partnership in the 2000s, New Delhi too found it prudent to constrain ties with Iran in order to smooth the way toward partnership with the United States. Because of China's permanent membership on the Security Council, and because of China's significant role in Persian Gulf security affairs (arms sales to Iran during the 1980–1988 war, its nuclear cooperation with Iran up to 1997, its capacity to substitute capital investment as European firms withdrew from Iranian energy projects), Washington often sought China's cooperation on Iran-related issues; 14 times between 1979 and 2014, by my count.[2] Beijing was time and again compelled to choose between supporting Iran or supporting the United States, as Washington usually insisted. These were difficult choices for Beijing. China valued its ties with Iran, which it viewed as a like-minded and capable country. But comity with Washington was the essential underpinning of China's economic development drive. Beijing became adept at avoiding stark choices, but when push came to shove, Beijing complied with US demands while figuring out other ways of helping Tehran. A degree of mutual strategic understanding between Tehran and Beijing was built up during these 30-some years of Chinese balancing between Washington and Beijing. Many in Tehran came to view China as a pragmatic and capable country that shared with Iran resentment about US domination.

India joined this game of courting Iran circa 2000 (roughly 20 years after Beijing!) when, under the leadership of Atal Bihari Vajpayee and Jaswant Singh of the Bharatiya Janata